even within US policy circles about the negative fallout of the Iraq invasion on the Afghan situation.[28] By 2004 Karzai made appeals for robust COIN measures while the insurgency was still in infancy, whereas Abdullah conceded with India that he was 'very worried' about the Taliban's activity.[29] But their appeals went unheeded. In June 2006, Karzai bitterly complained that 'for two years, I have systematically, consistently and on a daily basis warned the international community of what was developing in Afghanistan and of the need for a change of approach in this regard ... the international community [must] reassess the manner in which this war against terror is conducted'.[30] More than 669 Afghan civilians were killed in 2006 in about 350 armed attacks by the Taliban that were intentionally aimed at non-combatants.[31]

In December 2006, the US released the Baker-Hamilton Report on Iraq (also known as the Iraq Study Group Report).[32] Calling for the people of Iraq to take responsibility of their future, the report recommended an increase in the US military and diplomatic resources in Iraq to facilitate a credible transition as an external catalyst. Having invaded Iraq on the false pretense of Saddam Hussein's acquisition of weapons of mass destruction, the US had begun losing control over the situation on the ground in Afghanistan. Now it was intent on cutting its losses. Already uncomfortable with how the West had conducted itself in Afghanistan, the report further watered down India's hopes for sustained US presence in Afghanistan. Narayanan baldly asked US Under Secretary of State for Political Affairs, William J. Burns, 'after reading the Baker Hamilton Report on Iraq, we [India] want to know if the U.S. is going to stay the course in Afghanistan'.[33] Narayanan warned that if the US falters in Afghanistan, international jihadists would raise the same cry the Mujahideen had raised after the Soviet defeat.[34] India did not want to see a friendly neighbouring country become 'almost hostile' due to US mistakes. Burns promised Narayanan that the US would stay the course 'and more'.[35]

The combination of partisan advocacy of sending Indian troops to Iraq, a shift of US resources to the Middle East, and Indian reservations about the negative impact of the Iraq war on Afghanistan's security, had an interesting spinoff on how the US began viewing India's role in Afghanistan. In 2004, Washington took a U-turn on its decision to keep India out of Afghanistan's security sector and